

Event Details

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The Harness Engineering & Model Wrangling Hackathon Participant Guide

Welcome to the MongoDB Harness Engineering & Model Wrangling Hackathon!

This guide is your all-in-one resource for the event, including schedule, rules, technical resources, problem statements, judging information, and more. Please read this carefully; most answers can be found here.

1 Your Goal: Hackathon Themes

This hackathon revolves around building harnesses that can adapt, remember, and operate reliably over the long haul.

Your project must build in at least one of the following problem statements:

Statement One: Recursive Harnessing — Build a self-improving agent harness that automatically evolves its own architecture: updating rules, context policies, guardrails, tool access, and more. How can agents dynamically adapt their entire environment to fit a specific user, task, or use case?

Statement Two: Long Horizon Engineering — The highest-value agentic work spans hours, days, or weeks. Build a harness that sustains coherent memory across billions of tokens in one session, relentlessly optimizes toward long-term goals, and learns from hard metric signals to complete traditionally difficult tasks.

2 Getting Ready

📍 Location: The Malin Chelsea ([220 W 26th St, New York, NY 10001](#))

Arrival Instructions

To access the venue, all approved participants are required to sign in on-site upon arrival.

Venue Access: Information will be shared closer to the event date.

Wi-Fi Access

Network Name: Information will be shared closer to the event date.

Password: Information will be shared closer to the event date.

3 Connect with the Community

Join the Hackathon Discord to meet other participants, get official updates, and begin forming teams – the invite link will be shared closer to the event date.

Getting Started:

Access Hackathon-specific channels: Once you join, please make sure to read the #rules and #announcement channels.

Introduce yourself: In #intros, share who you are, the skills you bring, and what project you're looking to build.

Create a Team: In #team-search, find teammates before the hackathon (maximum team size of four)

Key Channels include:

#general: Socialize and meet other hackers.

#rules: On the day rules spanning from registration, product building, and pitching.

#announcements: Official updates and reminders from the CV Team.

#intros: Introduce yourself and what you're doing to everyone!

#team-search: Find teammates before the hackathon (maximum team size of four).

#questions: Ask any general questions to the CV Team by pinging @CV.

4 Schedule Overview

Saturday, September 26

9:00AM: Doors Open for Hackers · Breakfast Provided · Team Formation

10:00AM: Welcome Kick-Off

10:30AM: Hacking Begins

1:00PM: Lunch

5:00PM: Submissions Due

5:15PM – 6:45PM: First Round Judging

6:00PM: Dinner

7:00PM: Top 6 Demos · Closing Remarks

9:00PM: Doors Close

Wednesday, September 30

4:30PM: The Top 3 Teams Present On Stage at .local

In order to be eligible to win, finalists **MUST** be available on September 30th to attend MongoDB.local NYC and present their project. At least one member of your team must be present starting at 10 AM EST to demo your project to

conference attendees and collect votes, ultimately resulting in the top 3 teams who will demo on stage in the afternoon.

Hackathon Rules

Requirement for Finalists: Teams selected as finalists must build their project using the MongoDB Atlas Sandbox provided for the hackathon. Projects that do not will not be eligible for final judging or prizes.

Atlas Sandbox Access: Participants should have received an email with a link to join the MongoDB Atlas Sandbox for the hackathon. Please use this link to create your project environment. To be eligible as a finalist, your hackathon project must be built within this sandbox cluster.

Open Source: Repositories must be public.

Team Size: A maximum of four team members per team. Solo participants are allowed.

Demo Requirements: Your demo must only highlight the specific features, code, and functionality that your team built during the hackathon. Judges must be able to clearly identify what was created during the event. Failure to clearly identify your original contributions will result in immediate disqualification.

New Work Only: You may not present an existing project as your own work. Failure to clearly distinguish your contributions will result in immediate disqualification.

Banned Projects: Projects will be disqualified if they: violate legal, ethical, or platform policies, use code, data, or assets you do not have the rights to.

Sample Anti-Projects to NOT DO — STRICTLY NO:

AI Mental Health Advisor

Basic RAG Applications

Streamlit Applications

Image Analyzers

"AI for Education" Chatbot

AI Job Application Screener

AI Nutrition Coach

Personality Analyzers

Any project using AI to generate and give medical advice

Any project where a dashboard is the main feature

Sports analyzers or coaches

6 MongoDB and Partner-Provided Resources

Whether you're here to build your first AI agent or level up your existing stack, this guide is your one-stop shop for everything you may need throughout the hackathon. From various MongoDB tools and workshops, to partner APIs, SDKs, and demo resources.

[EXTERNAL] THE HARNE



Google Docs

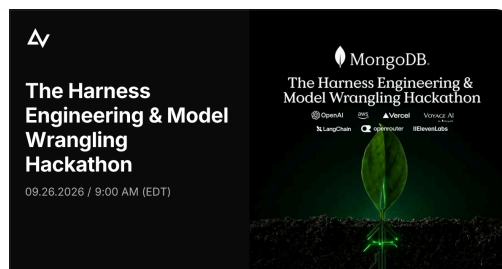


7 Submission Process

Teams should submit [here](#) when they have completed hacking. In the submission form, you will have to submit a short one minute demo video. This should be a video highlighting the specific features, code, and functionality that your team built during the hackathon.

Cerebral Valley — AI Eve

Cerebral Valley



Please double check that your repository is public, your demo link is accessible, and all team members have been added to the submission page.

8 Judging Process

Judging will be taking place on Saturday, September 26th and Wednesday, September 30th in three rounds. To be eligible for final judging and prizes, teams must participate in all three rounds and ensure their project uses MongoDB Atlas as a core component. Finalists MUST be available on September 30th to attend MongoDB.local NYC and present their project. At least one member of your team must be present starting at 10 AM EST to demo your project to conference attendees and collect votes, ultimately resulting in the top 3 teams who will demo on stage in the afternoon.

The judges are evaluating your technical demos in the following categories. *Show us what you have built* to solve our problem statements. Please do not show us a presentation. We'll be checking to ensure your project was built entirely during the event; no previous work is allowed.

First Round (09/26): [MongoDB NYC Hackathon](#) – General Vote

Hackers will be assigned to judging groups in different rooms of the venue. Each team will have ~3 minutes to live demo their project, followed by 1-2 minutes of Q&A.

The following criteria will be used:

Technical Demo (35%): How is the actual demo of the project? Does it impress you? Is it well-engineered and working?

Implementation Difficulty (30%): How hard is this project to recreate? Is the technical depth more than a few AI prompts away?

Creativity (15%): How creative is the project? Is this something you have never seen before?

Impact Potential (20%): Does the project address a significant real-world issue or pain point?

6 finalist teams will be selected ("Finalists"). The Finalists will demo to the hackathon attendees on stage after selection. *In the event that at least one team member from a Finalist is unable to attend MongoDB.local NYC, a backup team will be selected.*

Second Round (09/30): [MongoDB.local NYC](#) – Community Vote

The 6 Finalists will attend MongoDB.local NYC, and each Finalist's demo will be displayed in Cerebral Valley's showcase area.

MongoDB.local attendees will be provided the opportunity to vote for their favourite project here. You will only be able to vote once.

The 3 Finalists that receive the greatest number of votes will proceed to the Final Round ("Final Three").

Final Round (09/30): [MongoDB.local NYC](#) – Main Stage Presentation

The Final Three will be notified at 3:30 PM. Judges arrive at 4:15 PM, with judging and the main stage presentation at 4:30 PM (expected complete by 5:00 PM), where finalists present their demo live in front of the VIP judging panel and audience.

Finalists will have 3 minutes to present, with 3 minutes for Q&A.

Judges will select the 1st, 2nd, and 3rd place winners based on:

- **Technical Demo:** How is the actual demo of the project? Does it impress you? Is it well-engineered and working?
- **Implementation Difficulty:** How hard is this project to recreate? Is the technical depth more than a few AI prompts away?

- **Creativity:** How creative is the project? Is this something you have never seen before?
- **Impact Potential:** Does the project address a significant real-world issue or pain point?

9 Prizes

🏆 First Place:

MongoDB: \$7,000 US

ElevenLabs: 3 months Scale Tier

LangSmith: \$3,000 of Credits

Vercel: \$1,800 of v0 Credits

🥈 Second Place:

MongoDB: \$5,000 USD

ElevenLabs: 3 months Pro Tier

LangSmith: \$2,000 of Credits

Vercel: \$1,200 of v0 Credits

🥉 Third Place:

MongoDB: \$3,000 USD

ElevenLabs: 3 months Pro Tier

LangSmith: \$1,000 of Credits

Vercel: \$600 of v0 Credits

? If you have any questions, please email ajc@cerebralvalley.ai or message on Discord.